Risk-Aware Predictive Vertical Handover for UAV Communications in Heterogeneous Wireless Networks

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Abstract

Unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) operating in heterogeneous wireless networks require seamless connectivity across multiple radio access technologies, including fifth-generation (5G), Long-Term Evolution (LTE), and Wi-Fi. During aerial missions, UAVs frequently traverse coverage boundaries among these networks, creating vertical-handover (VHO) challenges involving decision latency, ping-pong handovers, and fixed attribute weights that cannot adapt to dynamic channel conditions and flight phases. This study proposes the long short-term memory (LSTM)-attention-based adaptive vertical handover algorithm (LAAVHA) and further develops the attention-LSTM enhanced risk-aware vertical handover algorithm (ALERA) using adaptive dynamic hysteresis (ADH) and a risk-sensitive technique for order preference by similarity to the ideal solution (RS-TOPSIS). LAAVHA integrates stacked-LSTM state prediction, attention-based dynamic weighting, improved TOPSIS ranking, and dual-hysteresis decision-making. ADH adapts hysteresis parameters to flight speed and serving-network channel fluctuations, while

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RS-TOPSIS penalizes volatile closeness scores to improve candidate ranking. Simulation results demonstrate reduced unnecessary handovers, improved decision efficiency, sustained service continuity, and greater robustness to abrupt channel variations in heterogeneous wireless networks. In 50 random scenarios, the decision-level handover count is only 0.24, achieving 84.8%-99.1% reduction compared to eight baseline algorithms, while simultaneously achieving the highest mean throughput (2.00 Mbps) and lowest mean delay (1.00 ms) among evaluated algorithms. The simulation evaluates network selection decision stability; the complete protocol-stack handover process—including authentication, link reestablishment, and data forwarding—remains outside the current scope.

Keywords: UAV communications, heterogeneous wireless networks, vertical handover decision, network selection, decision-level simulation, LSTM, attention mechanism, adaptive decision

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1. Introduction

Unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs) are increasingly deployed in heterogeneous wireless network environments, where multiple radio access technologies—including fifth-generation (5G), Long-Term Evolution (LTE), and Wi-Fi—coexist with overlapping coverage areas. UAV mobility introduces unique vertical handover (VHO) challenges that differ fundamentally from ground-based scenarios: rapid altitude changes, high-speed boundary crossings, and three-dimensional trajectory variations create dynamic channel conditions that demand intelligent network selection strategies. The core technical challenge lies in managing seamless connectivity across coverage boundaries while maintaining quality of service for real-time aerial data transmission [1, 2, 3]. This study addresses the network selection decision problem: determining when to initiate a handover and which target network to select, based on predicted channel conditions and dynamic attribute weighting. The complete protocol-stack handover process—including authentication, link reestablishment, and data forwarding—is not evaluated in the current decision-level simulation platform. Existing VHO methods mainly employ multiple attribute decision making (MADM) [7], including the technique for order preference by similarity to the ideal solution (TOPSIS) [8, 9, 10], VIsekriterijumska Optimizacija I Kompromisno Resenje (VIKOR, multi-criteria optimization and compromise solution) [11], and the Grey re-

lational analysis (GRA), complex proportional assessment (COPRAS), stable preference ordering toward ideal solution (SPOTIS), and simple additive weighting (SAW) methods [12]. Fuzzy-VHO applies fuzzy inference to handover decisions [4]. These approaches have two main limitations. First, weights are typically fixed using entropy weighting or the analytic hierarchy process [12, 13, 14, 15], limiting adaptation to varying flight phases and channel conditions. Second, decisions rely on current network indicators without predicting future states, potentially delaying handovers until link failure when a UAV approaches coverage limits [16, 17]. Deep reinforcement learning improves handover decisions [16, 17, 18], but remains limited by black-box decision-making and unstable training, which undermine interpretability and reliability in safety-critical aerial missions.

LSTM networks alleviate vanishing gradients through gated structures [19] and capture long-range temporal dependencies. They have been applied to handover decisions and network-state prediction in 5G heterogeneous networks [20, 21, 22]. However, a single LSTM has two limitations. It treats the five network-state indicators as independent temporal series, failing to model their coupling, such as the negative correlation between throughput and packet loss and the relationship between signal-to-interference-plus-noise ratio (SINR) and delay. Moreover, its predictions still depend on fixed or manually assigned attribute weights, limiting adaptation to flight phase and mobility state.

VHO in UAV heterogeneous wireless networks involves two key challenges. Conventional MADM methods use fixed weights and lack temporal prediction, while a single LSTM network cannot dynamically adjust attribute weights. Moreover, signal fluctuations are minor during steady flight but can intensify near coverage boundaries or obstacles, making fixed thresholds and confirmation windows unsuitable for both conditions. Limited algorithmic adaptability therefore increases handover instability, while dynamic environments require greater environmental awareness.

To address these related challenges, this paper proposes a layered solution. At the algorithm level, LAAVHA integrates LSTM networks and attention mechanisms to overcome the fixed weighting and limited temporal prediction of conventional MADM methods. LAAVHA comprises three stages: prediction, weighting, and decision. A stacked LSTM predicts short-term changes in candidate networks; self-attention combines the current network-state matrix with mobility features, such as flight speed and altitude, to derive dynamic attribute weights; and an improved TOPSIS matrix integrates current

and predicted states. Candidate ranking and handover decisions are stabilized through dual hysteresis based on a TOPSIS closeness-score advantage threshold and a consecutive-confirmation window. Dynamic weighting and predictive modeling enable stable candidate evaluation during UAV aerial missions in heterogeneous wireless networks. These missions involve wide-area flight, rapid traversal of 5G/LTE/Wi-Fi coverage boundaries, abrupt channel variations caused by boundaries or obstructions, and continuous transmission of mission-critical data streams. To address these conditions, ADH and RS-TOPSIS are integrated into LAAVHA, forming ALERA.

ADH overcomes the limitations of fixed thresholds and confirmation windows in balancing handover stability and responsiveness. It measures channel variation using the standard deviation of serving-network SINR over the latest five decision periods and adjusts handover conditions according to flight speed. Higher channel variation increases the score-advantage threshold to suppress transient disturbances, whereas higher speed shortens the confirmation window to enable timely handovers near rapidly changing coverage boundaries. Therefore, ADH maintains responsiveness under stable conditions while improving anti-chattering capability during severe channel fluctuations. In addition, RS-TOPSIS mitigates the risk of selecting candidates with high current scores but unstable recent performance. It retains the latest five TOPSIS closeness scores, computes their standard deviation, and applies a variation-based risk penalty to the current closeness score. The resulting robust score captures both instantaneous performance and historical stability, preventing transient peaks in volatile channels from triggering false handovers.

Simulation results show that LAAVHA achieves the lowest mean handover count (0.24) among 11 algorithms, reducing handovers by $84.8\% - 99.1\%$ versus eight baselines; 38 of 50 runs require no handover. End-to-end QoS evaluation demonstrates that LAAVHA simultaneously achieves the highest mean throughput (2.00 Mbps) and lowest mean delay (1.00 ms) among evaluated algorithms, confirming that handover reduction stems from intelligent decision-making rather than excessive conservatism. Removing the LSTM prediction or attention-based dynamic-weight branch increases the count to 1.08 and 2.00, respectively, confirming their complementary roles in handover stability. ALERA completes all necessary handovers during sustained link degradation while producing no false handovers under transient fluctuations, whereas a fixed low-threshold scheme causes two additional ping-pong handovers. These results demonstrate that ADH and RS-TOPSIS enhance

robustness under channel fluctuations without suppressing necessary handovers.

2. Network Scenario and Network-State Parameters

A UAV aerial mission is considered over a 2000 m $\times$ 2000 m heterogeneous wireless network coverage area, with a UAV following a predefined route at $50 - 150$ m altitude and $5 - 30$ m/s cruise speed. Wi-Fi, LTE, and 5G serve as candidate networks with different coverage ranges and deployment densities. Wi-Fi hotspots have an approximate 200 m radius and are placed near ground control stations and key operational sites. LTE base stations provide $1 - 2$ km coverage and are sparsely deployed along the route. 5G base stations, with an approximate 500 m radius, are concentrated in the eastern data-aggregation area, offering high-rate access but incomplete coverage continuity. The UAV periodically collects the state of each candidate network for handover decisions [23].

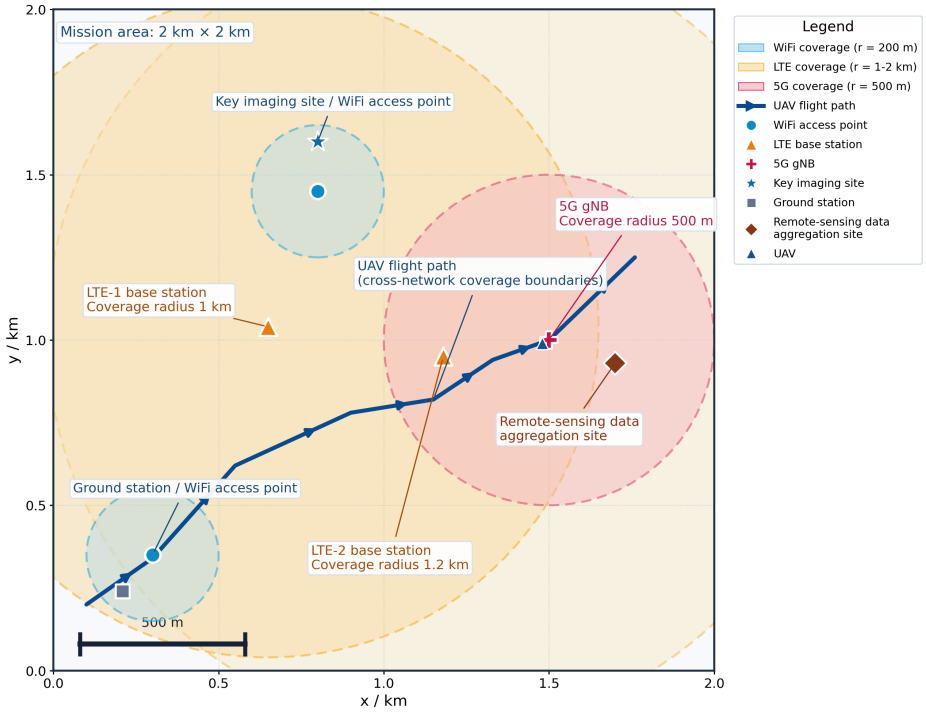


Figure 1: Heterogeneous wireless network coverage and UAV trajectory in the mission area.

Wi-Fi, LTE, and 5G provide overlapping coverage at different scales (Figure 1). Wi-Fi hotspots mainly serve ground stations and key imaging sites; LTE base stations offer relatively continuous wide-area connectivity; and 5G base stations provide high-rate transmission within the eastern data-aggregation area but with limited coverage continuity. The 5G next generation Node B (gNB) provides 5G coverage, radio-resource scheduling, and high-rate data transmission. As the UAV follows its route, it traverses overlapping coverage areas and requires VHO when the serving network degrades; another candidate offers better overall performance. The coverage scales correspond to the specified radii and define the basis for subsequent network-state collection and candidate evaluation.

For candidate network i, the state vector at time t is defined as:

$$S_i(t) = [\mathrm{SINR}_i(t),\ \mathrm{RSRP}_i(t),\ D_i(t),\ T_i(t),\ \mathrm{PLR}_i(t)]\,, \tag{1}$$

where $\mathrm{SINR}_i(t)$, $\mathrm{RSRP}_i(t)$, $D_i(t)$, $T_i(t)$, and $\mathrm{PLR}_i(t)$ denote the SINR,

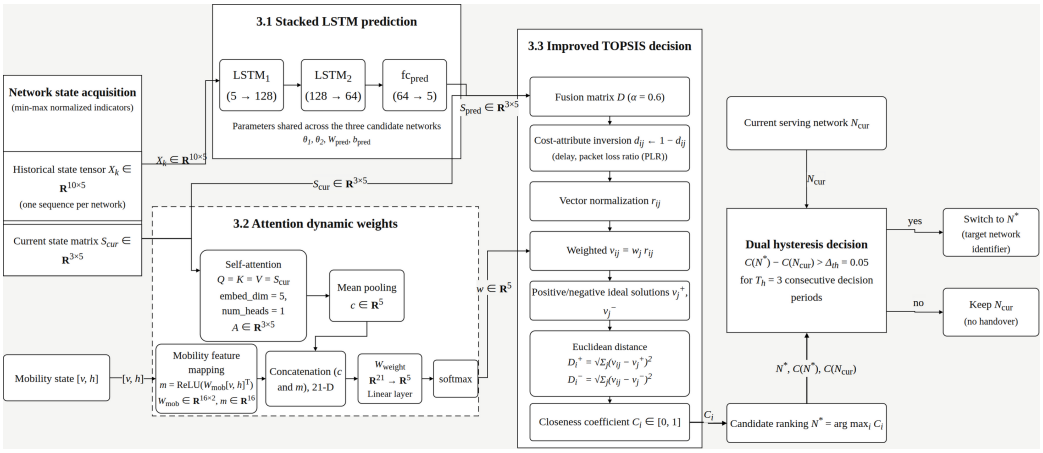
reference signal received power, end-to-end delay, throughput, and packet loss ratio of candidate i at time t, respectively. These five indicators characterize candidate-network performance from complementary perspectives. As the UAV moves across coverage boundaries, $\mathrm{SINR}_i(t)$ typically declines from tens of decibels toward the noise floor, reflecting signal degradation caused by distance and obstruction and providing a direct handover cue. $\mathrm{RSRP}_i(t)$, together with $\mathrm{SINR}_i(t)$, determines whether the link budget meets the demodulation threshold; below receiver sensitivity, reliable physical-layer connectivity cannot be established even with acceptable SINR. The delay $D_i(t)$ represents the round-trip time of a packet between the ground station and UAV application layer, affecting responsiveness and safety margins during high-speed cruise. Throughput $T_i(t)$ measures deliverable payload bits per unit time; insufficient throughput prevents time-sensitive data payloads from being transmitted during a single overflight. While $\mathrm{PLR}_i(t)$ reflects transmission reliability, even with adequate signal strength and throughput, high $\mathrm{PLR}_i(t)$ can cause data loss or quality degradation. $\mathrm{SINR}_i(t)$, $\mathrm{RSRP}_i(t)$, and $T_i(t)$ are benefit criteria, whereas $D_i(t)$ and $\mathrm{PLR}_i(t)$ are cost criteria. Min-max normalization maps all indicators to $[0, 1]$, where larger normalized values indicate better performance [11].

Equation (1) provides the common input interface for the subsequent algorithm chain. Stacking $S_i(t)$ for the three candidates at time t forms the current-state matrix $S_{\mathrm{cur}} \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times5}$, which feeds the attention-based weight-generation module (Section 3.2). Stacking one candidate's states over 10 consecutive decision periods forms the historical-state tensor $X_k \in \mathbf{R}^{10\times5}$, which feeds the stacked-LSTM prediction module (Section 3.1). Therefore, the network-state parameters in Section 2 capture both cross-candidate differences and the short-term evolution of individual networks induced by UAV mobility.

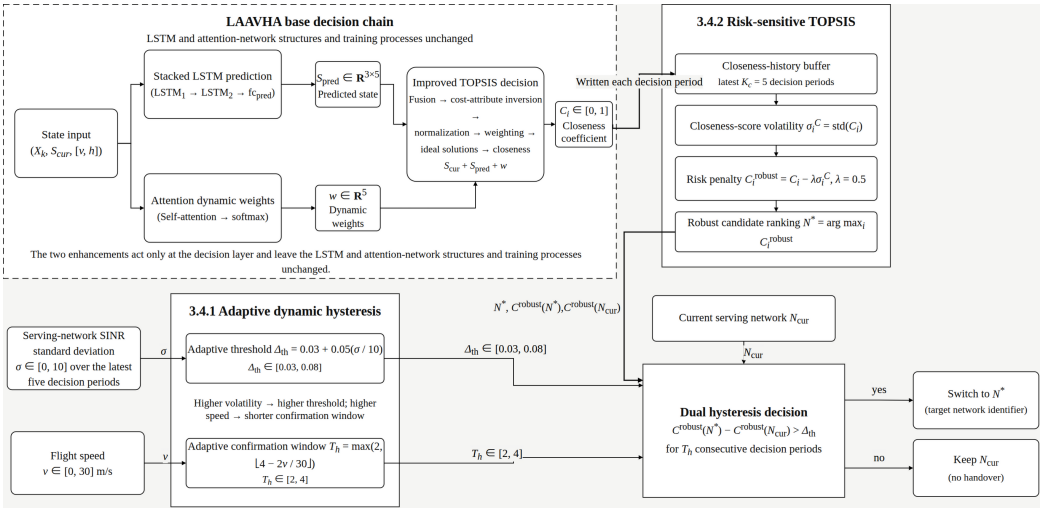
UAV motion continuously changes candidate signal and transmission performance. Relying only on current indicators may prevent timely handover near coverage edges, increasing link-interruption risk and degrading service continuity; UAV cellular-network coverage and handover characteristics are discussed in [23]. Recent work has also investigated 5G ping-pong handover suppression through self-optimization [24]. Accordingly, the algorithm uses network states from recent decision periods as temporal inputs to predict short-term future states and combines them with the current state for the final handover decision.

3. LAAVHA Adaptive Vertical Handover Algorithm

Based on the network scenario and state parameters (Section 2), this section proposes LAAVHA, an adaptive VHO algorithm that integrates LSTM and an attention mechanism. It overcomes the fixed weighting and lack of temporal prediction in conventional MADM methods for UAV aerial missions in heterogeneous wireless networks. Using the five-dimensional state vector and sliding window (Section 2), LAAVHA performs stacked-LSTM prediction, attention-based dynamic weighting, and improved TOPSIS decision-making with predicted states. ADH and RS-TOPSIS are then incorporated to form ALERA.



(a) LAAVHA algorithm framework



(b) ALERA algorithm framework

Figure 2: LAAVHA and ALERA algorithm frameworks.

LAAVHA comprises network-state prediction, dynamic-weight generation, candidate ranking, and dual-hysteresis decision-making, with ADH and RS-TOPSIS extending the decision chain (Figure 2). These modules form a sequential flow around a common network state. The historical sequence X_k, collected and normalized in Section 2, enters the stacked LSTM to produce the next-period predicted state S_{pred}. Additionally, the current-state matrix S_{cur} enters the attention module with mobility features, including speed and

altitude, to generate dynamic weight w. Then S_{cur}, S_{pred}, and w are combined in improved TOPSIS to obtain candidate closeness score C_i. Finally, C_i and the current serving network N_{cur} enter the hysteresis decision module with ALERA enhancements to determine the final handover. Therefore, Section 3.1 predicts future states, Section 3.2 determines attribute importance, Section 3.3 ranks candidates using current and future states, and Section 3.4 determines whether handover is appropriate under channel fluctuations.

In the prediction branch, θ_1 and θ_2 denote the parameters of the two LSTM layers, while W_{pred} and b_{pred} represent the prediction-head weight and bias. In the attention branch, Q, K, and V indicate the query, key, and value; A signifies the attention output; c corresponds to the mean-pooled context vector; v and h are flight speed and altitude; W_{mob} maps them to the mobility feature m; and W_{weight} projects the concatenated c and m to dynamic weight w. In the TOPSIS branch, D represents the fused decision matrix; α denotes the fusion coefficient; d_{ij}, r_{ij}, and v_{ij} denote the candidate's fused, normalized, and weighted elements, respectively; v_j^+ and v_j^- indicate the positive and negative ideal solutions; D_i^+ and D_i^- signify the Euclidean distances of candidate i from these solutions; C_i is its closeness score; N^* corresponds to the selected target network; and Δ_{th} and T_h are the handover threshold and consecutive-confirmation window. In the enhancement branch, K_c denotes the closeness-history length, σ_i^C represents the standard deviation of candidate i's scores, λ indicates the risk coefficient, C_i^{robust} signifies the risk-adjusted score, and σ is the serving network's SINR standard deviation over the latest five periods.

3.1. Network-State Prediction using a Stacked LSTM

The time-window length is set to $T_s = 10$, covering 10 consecutive decision periods over 1.0 s with a decision interval of $\tau = 0.1$ s. Candidate networks $k \in \{1, 2, 3\}$ represent 5G, LTE, and Wi-Fi, respectively. The historical input tensor $X_k \in \mathbf{R}^{10\times 5}$ is constructed by row-wise stacking the normalized five-dimensional state vectors across the 10 periods. The prediction target is the next-period state vector $\hat{s}_k(t+\tau) \in \mathbf{R}^5$:

$$h_{1,k} = \text{LSTM}_1(X_k; \theta_1), \qquad h_{1,k} \in \mathbf{R}^{10\times 128}, \tag{2}$$

$$h_{2,k} = \text{LSTM}_2(h_{1,k}; \theta_2), \qquad h_{2,k} \in \mathbf{R}^{10\times 64}, \tag{3}$$

$$\hat{s}_k(t+\tau) = W_{\text{pred}} h_{2,k}[-1] + b_{\text{pred}}, \qquad \hat{s}_k \in \mathbf{R}^5. \tag{4}$$

where θ_1 and θ_2 denote the trainable parameters of the two LSTM layers, including the weights and biases of the input, forget, and output gates and

cell states, while $W_{\text{pred}} \in \mathbf{R}^{5\times 64}$ and $b_{\text{pred}} \in \mathbf{R}^5$ represent the fully connected prediction-head weight and bias, respectively, and $h_{2,k}[-1]$ indicates the final output of LSTM_2. Equations (2)–(4) define the prediction pipeline: 10 steps $\times$ 5 indicators $\rightarrow$ $\text{LSTM}_1(5 \rightarrow 128) \rightarrow \text{LSTM}_2(128 \rightarrow 64)$ $\rightarrow$fc_pred$(64 \rightarrow 5)$. The three candidate networks share θ_1, θ_2, W_{pred}, and b_{pred}, while using their respective historical sequences X_k. The resulting predictions are stacked into $S_{\text{pred}} \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 5}$, representing the next-period values of the five indicators for each network.

The prediction branch is trained using supervised learning with mean squared error (MSE) loss. Given training samples indexed by $n = 1, \ldots, N$, where each sample comprises a historical sequence $X_k^{(n)}$ and the corresponding ground-truth next-period state $S_{\text{target}}^{(n)}$, the loss function is:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{pred}} = \frac{1}{N} \sum_{n=1}^{N} \left\| S_{\text{pred}}^{(n)} - S_{\text{target}}^{(n)} \right\|_2^2. \tag{5}$$

The parameters θ_1, θ_2, W_{pred}, and b_{pred} are updated via backpropagation using the Adam optimizer. Training uses an 80%/20% train/validation split with early stopping when validation loss does not decrease for 10 consecutive epochs. This supervised objective trains the LSTM branch to accurately forecast short-term network-state evolution, which subsequently feeds the TOPSIS decision module.

S_{pred} is not a direct handover score but a comparable prediction of each candidate's next-period state derived from its historical sequence X_k. In Section 3.3, Equation (12), it is fused with the current state S_{cur}, enabling TOPSIS to incorporate both current measurements and short-term predictions. Without S_{pred}, handover decisions would rely solely on passive ranking of S_{cur}, as evaluated by the LAAVHA-L ablation variant.

3.2. Dynamic Weight Generation for Flight Phases

Network-attribute importance varies with the VHO decisions. During cruise, link stability and flight-control delay are more critical to safety, whereas during image return at imaging sites, throughput and packet loss become more important for timely and reliable transmission of high-resolution images [25]. Fixed weights cannot capture these changing priorities.

To capture phase-dependent requirements, LAAVHA employs self-attention [26, 27]. The five-dimensional state vectors of the three candidates are row-wise stacked into $S_{\text{cur}} \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 5}$, with $Q = K = V = S_{\text{cur}}$, `embed_dim` =

5, and `num_heads` = 1. The `embed_dim` denotes the feature dimension of each attention input and is set to 5, corresponding to the normalized SINR, RSRP, delay, throughput, and packet loss ratio indicators, and `num_heads` represents the number of parallel attention heads and is set to 1. With five attributes, multiple heads would provide too few features per head and reduce weight interpretability. A single head therefore learns attribute correlations directly. The self-attention mechanism captures cross-network dependencies among the candidate networks, where the attention matrix quantifies how each network's state should be aggregated based on inter-network relationships. Cross-network mean pooling then extracts the attribute-level context $c \in \mathbf{R}^5$ from the attention output. The resulting representations are combined with UAV mobility features to generate dynamic attribute weights for subsequent TOPSIS-based network selection. Flight speed v and altitude h are mapped by $W_{\text{mob}} \in \mathbf{R}^{16\times 2}$ to mobility feature $m \in \mathbf{R}^{16}$. The concatenated results are projected by a fully connected layer and normalized by softmax to obtain the five-dimensional dynamic weight w:

$$Q = K = V = S_{\text{cur}} \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 5}, \tag{6}$$

$$A = \text{Attention}(Q, K, V) = \text{softmax}\left(\frac{QK^\top}{\sqrt{5}}\right) V, \quad A \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 5}, \tag{7}$$

$$c = \text{mean}(A, \text{dim} = 0) \in \mathbf{R}^5, \tag{8}$$

$$m = \text{ReLU}\big(W_{\text{mob}}[v, h]^\top\big), \quad W_{\text{mob}} : \mathbf{R}^2 \to \mathbf{R}^{16}, \quad m \in \mathbf{R}^{16}, \tag{9}$$

$$w = \text{softmax}(W_{\text{weight}}[c \parallel m]), \quad W_{\text{weight}} : \mathbf{R}^{21} \to \mathbf{R}^5, \quad w \in \mathbf{R}^5, \quad \sum_j w_j = 1. \tag{10}$$

Equations (6)–(10) define the dynamic-weight procedure: $S_{\text{cur}} \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 5}$ enters self-attention, producing the 3×5 matrix A; cross-network mean pooling yields the five-dimensional attribute context c; $W_{\text{mob}} : 2 \to 16$ maps speed and altitude to the 16-dimensional mobility feature m; and their 21-dimensional concatenation is projected by W_{weight} and softmax-normalized to obtain the five-dimensional dynamic weight w. The self-attention mechanism does not directly model attribute-to-attribute correlations; instead, it captures cross-network dependencies in the state matrix S_{cur}, and the subsequent mean pooling and projection layers (Equations (8)–(10)) transform this network-level context into attribute-level weights w.

The output w is not an independent assessment of a network quality

measure but an input to the TOPSIS weighting step in Section 3.3. In Equation (15), $v_{ij} = w_j r_{ij}$ applies w_j to the jth attribute of the fused matrix D, allowing the importance of SINR, RSRP, delay, throughput, and packet loss ratio to adapt to the current network and flight state. Therefore, the LSTM branch predicts future state changes, while the attention branch determines current attribute importance; both contribute to the final TOPSIS closeness score C_i.

Unlike the LSTM prediction branch, the attention-based weight-generation module is not trained via gradient descent. Instead, its parameters (attention mechanism weights, W_{mob}, and W_{weight}) are initialized using standard PyTorch initialization schemes (Xavier uniform for linear layers) and remain fixed during training. The module functions as a deterministic feature extractor that transforms the current network state S_{cur} and mobility features $[v, h]$ into dynamic attribute weights w through forward-pass computation only.

Although the attention module's parameters remain fixed, the output weights $w = f(S_{\text{cur}}, v, h)$ dynamically vary as a function of the current network state and mobility features. As network conditions and flight phases evolve across decision periods, the same fixed transformation produces different attribute importances, enabling input-driven adaptivity rather than parameter-driven learning. This design trades end-to-end trainability for architectural simplicity while preserving the core benefit: context-aware weight adjustment without manual tuning.

This design choice has two motivations. First, there is no ground-truth target for what the optimal attribute weights should be at each decision period; constructing such supervision would require domain expertise or iterative reward-based tuning. While reinforcement learning could optimize weights using handover-count-based rewards, our preliminary experiments showed that the fixed-initialization structure already achieves substantial improvement (Section 4.5), making the additional training complexity and data requirements unnecessary for the current performance target. Second, the attention mechanism's structural inductive bias—specifically, the query-key interaction (Equation (7)) naturally capturing attribute correlations and the mobility projection (Equations (9)–(10)) adapting to flight phase—provides meaningful feature transformation even without gradient-based parameter updates, analogous to how carefully designed convolutional kernels can extract useful features before fine-tuning. Experimental results in Section 4.5 demonstrate that this initialization-based weight generation, combined with

trained LSTM prediction, achieves substantial handover reduction compared to fixed-weight baselines (0.24 vs. 2.00 for entropy weighting), validating the effectiveness of the attention module's structural design even without end-to-end training.

3.3. Improved TOPSIS Decision Making with Fused Predicted States

This subsection integrates the preceding learning modules. S_{pred} from Section 3.1 provides the short-term future state, w from Section 3.2 provides phase-dependent attribute weights, and S_{cur} from Section 2 provides the current state. Since aerial mission performance depends jointly on signal strength, transmission capability, and reliability, no single indicator defines the optimal network. TOPSIS ranks candidates by their proximity to the virtual ideal and negative-ideal networks [8, 9]. To incorporate future conditions, LAAVHA fuses the current and predicted states to form the decision matrix:

$$s_{\text{norm}} = \frac{s - s_{\min}}{s_{\max} - s_{\min}}, \quad \text{for each indicator } j, \tag{11}$$

$$d_{ij} = \alpha s_{\text{cur}}(i,j) + (1-\alpha) s_{\text{pred}}(i,j), \quad \alpha = 0.6, \tag{12}$$

$$d_{ij} \leftarrow 1 - d_{ij}, \quad j \in \{\text{delay}, \text{PLR}\}. \tag{13}$$

where $i = 1, 2, 3$ denotes the candidate network index for 5G, LTE, and Wi-Fi, respectively, j represents the attribute index for SINR, RSRP, delay, throughput, and packet loss ratio, s indicates the original attribute value, $s_{\min}$ and $s_{\max}$ are its minimum and maximum values across candidates in the current period, s_{norm} indicates the normalized value in $[0, 1]$, $s_{\text{cur}}(i,j)$ and $s_{\text{pred}}(i,j)$ correspond to the normalized current and LSTM-predicted next-period values, respectively and d_{ij} denotes the resulting fused element of decision matrix D. The fusion coefficient $\alpha = 0.6$, justified experimentally in Section 4.1, prioritizes current measurements while retaining predictive guidance. Delay and packet loss ratio are cost criteria; therefore, Equation (13) inverts their normalized values so that all TOPSIS inputs follow a larger-is-better orientation. The resulting fused decision matrix $D \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times 5}$ then enters

standard TOPSIS:

$$r_{ij} = \frac{d_{ij}}{\sqrt{\sum_{k=1}^{3} d_{kj}^2}}, \tag{14}$$

$$v_{ij} = w_j r_{ij}, \tag{15}$$

$$v_j^+ = \max_i v_{ij}, \quad v_j^- = \min_i v_{ij}, \tag{16}$$

$$D_i^+ = \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{5} (v_{ij} - v_j^+)^2}, \quad D_i^- = \sqrt{\sum_{j=1}^{5} (v_{ij} - v_j^-)^2}, \tag{17}$$

$$C_i = \frac{D_i^-}{D_i^+ + D_i^-}, \quad C_i \in [0, 1]. \tag{18}$$

where r_{ij} denotes the vector-normalized element of fused matrix D, and $\sqrt{\sum_{k=1}^{3} d_{kj}^2}$ represents the Euclidean norm of attribute j across the three candidates, with k as the summation index, w_j indicates the dynamic weight of attribute j from the attention module, v_{ij} signifies the weighted normalized element, v_j^+ and v_j^- correspond to the positive and negative ideal solutions, defined as the largest and smallest weighted normalized values for attribute j, respectively, D_i^+ and D_i^- are the distances of candidate i from these solutions, and $C_i \in [0, 1]$ is its relative closeness. Therefore, Equations (14)–(18) convert the 3×5 fused matrix into three closeness scores through normalization, dynamic weighting, ideal-solution determination, and Euclidean-distance calculation. A value closer to 1 indicates stronger overall support for image transmission, flight-control responsiveness, and link reliability.

$$N^* = \arg\max_i C_i, \tag{19}$$

$$\text{Decision} = \begin{cases} \text{switch to } N^*, & C(N^*) - C(N_{\text{cur}}) > \Delta_{\text{th}} \text{ and lasts } T_h \text{ consecutive cycles}, \\ \text{keep } N_{\text{cur}}, & \text{otherwise}, \end{cases} \tag{20}$$

where N^* denotes the candidate with the highest current closeness, N_{cur} represents the serving network, $C(N^*)$ and $C(N_{\text{cur}})$ indicate their respective TOPSIS closeness scores, Δ_{th} specifies the required score advantage, and T_h specifies its required persistence. This study sets $\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.05$ and $T_h = 3$ based on experiments in Section 4.1. To suppress ping-pong handovers caused by transient fluctuations, handover occurs only when N^* ex-

ceeds N_{cur} by more than $\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.05$ for $T_h = 3$ consecutive periods. Algorithm 1 integrates prediction, dynamic-weight generation, TOPSIS ranking, and hysteresis adjudication into the LAAVHA procedure.

Algorithm 1 LAAVHA vertical-handover decision procedure

Require: Historical states $\{X_k\}_{k=1}^{3}$, current state S_{cur}, mobility state $[v, h]$, serving network N_{cur}, previous confirmed candidate N_{cand}, and its consecutive count q

Ensure: Handover decision Decision and updated N_{cur}, N_{cand}, and q

Stage 0: Initialization
Read the current decision-period state and previous hysteresis state N_{cand}, q
Stage 1: State prediction and dynamic-weight generation
for $k \leftarrow 1$ **to** 3 **do**
    $h_{1,k} \leftarrow \text{LSTM}_1(X_k; \theta_1)$, $h_{2,k} \leftarrow \text{LSTM}_2(h_{1,k}; \theta_2)$
    $s_{\text{pred},k} \leftarrow W_{\text{pred}} h_{2,k}[-1] + b_{\text{pred}}$
end for
Stack $\{s_{\text{pred},k}\}_{k=1}^{3}$ as S_{pred}
$A \leftarrow \text{Attention}(S_{\text{cur}}, S_{\text{cur}}, S_{\text{cur}})$, $c \leftarrow \text{mean}(A, \text{dim} = 0)$
$m \leftarrow \text{ReLU}(W_{\text{mob}}[v, h]^{\top})$, $w \leftarrow \text{softmax}(W_{\text{weight}}[c \parallel m])$
Stage 2: Fused-TOPSIS candidate ranking
for $i \leftarrow 1$ **to** 3 **do**
    for $j \leftarrow 1$ **to** 5 **do**
        $d_{ij} \leftarrow 0.6 s_{\text{cur}}(i, j) + 0.4 s_{\text{pred}}(i, j)$
        if $j \in \{\text{delay}, \text{PLR}\}$ **then** $d_{ij} \leftarrow 1 - d_{ij}$
        end if
    end for
end for
Compute r_{ij}, v_{ij}, v_j^{+}, v_j^{-}, D_i^{+}, D_i^{-}, and C_i using Equations (14)–(18)
$N^{*} \leftarrow \arg\max_i C_i$
Stage 3: Dual-hysteresis handover decision
if $N^{*} \neq N_{\text{cand}}$ **then**
    $N_{\text{cand}} \leftarrow N^{*}$, $q \leftarrow 0$
end if
if $C(N^{*}) - C(N_{\text{cur}}) > \Delta_{\text{th}}$ **then**
    $q \leftarrow q + 1$
else
    $q \leftarrow 0$
end if
if $q \geq T_h$ **then**
    Decision $\leftarrow$ switch to N^{*}, $N_{\text{cur}} \leftarrow N^{*}$
else
    Decision $\leftarrow$ keep N_{cur}
end if
return Decision, N_{cur}, N_{cand}, q

Algorithm 1 shows that the stacked LSTM generates only the predicted state S_{pred}, while the attention module generates only the dynamic weight w. Both are combined with S_{cur} in TOPSIS to compute C_i, followed by dual hysteresis for the handover decision. The sequence follows Equations (2)–(20).

3.4. ALERA Enhanced Risk-Aware Vertical Handover Algorithm

Section 3.3 establishes the base decision chain from state prediction and dynamic weighting to candidate ranking and handover, but its dual hysteresis uses fixed parameters. Although effective in stable channels, fixed thresholds and windows cannot balance fluctuation resistance and handover timeliness during coverage-boundary crossings, obstruction, or major speed changes. Standard TOPSIS also ranks candidates by current closeness without accounting for score-series risk. Without retraining the LSTM-attention model, this section introduces ADH and RS-TOPSIS. ADH uses serving-network SINR history and flight speed to dynamically update Δ_{th} and T_h in Equation (20), while RS-TOPSIS uses the C_i sequence from Section 3.3 to derive risk-penalized C_i^{robust} for final candidate ranking, forming ALERA.

3.4.1. Adaptive Hysteresis Parameters

Adaptive hysteresis margins and trigger windows improve handover decisions in heterogeneous and ultra-dense networks [28, 29, 30, 31]. Accordingly, fixed Δ_{th} and T_h are replaced with context-aware values. The variable σ denotes the standard deviation of serving network SINR over the latest five decision periods, while v denotes real-time flight speed, and σ is derived from the SINR history in Equation (1), and v is the mobility input used for dynamic weighting in Section 3.2. ADH thus reuses available states and adapts only the threshold and confirmation window of the final hysteresis decision. The adaptive threshold and window are:

$$\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.03 + 0.05 \left(\frac{\sigma}{10} \right), \quad \sigma \in [0, 10], \tag{21}$$

$$T_h = \max \left(2, \left\lfloor 4 - \frac{2v}{30} \right\rfloor \right), \quad v \in [0, 30] \text{ m/s}. \tag{22}$$

Equation (21) sets a base threshold of 0.03 under stable channels ($\sigma \approx 0$), below the fixed value of 0.05 and allowing faster response to sustained degradation. Under severe variation ($\sigma \approx 10$), it increases linearly to 0.08, strengthening the handover barrier. Equation (22) sets a window of 4 at low speed

($v \approx 5$ m/s) for sufficient confirmation and decreases it to a minimum of 2 as speed increases, enabling timely handover near coverage boundaries. Therefore, $\Delta_{\text{th}} \in [0.03, 0.08]$ and $T_h \in [2, 4]$ retain anti-chattering capability under extreme conditions. At 30 m/s, the UAV travels 3 m in a 0.1 s period; $T_h = 4$ therefore permits 12 m of movement, potentially shifting the UAV from Wi-Fi-center to edge coverage before confirmation. $T_h = 2$ limits this to 6 m and better supports boundary handover. At 5 m/s, $T_h = 4$ corresponds to only 2 m, allowing longer confirmation to filter transient variations with limited obsolescence risk. The settings of Δ_{th}, T_h, and the σ history length are validated experimentally in Section 4.1.

3.4.2. Risk-Sensitive TOPSIS

Original TOPSIS ranks candidates by current closeness C_i, obtained from Equation (18) by fusing S_{cur}, S_{pred}, and w. RS-TOPSIS retains this prediction and weighting process while adding a risk constraint to the C_i series. Based on the lower-confidence-bound (LCB) principle, a historical-variation penalty is subtracted from each candidate score:

$$C_i^{\text{robust}} = C_i - \lambda \sigma_i^C, \quad \lambda = 0.5, \tag{23}$$

where σ_i^C denotes the standard deviation of the latest five scores for network i, and $\lambda = 0.5$ is the risk-aversion coefficient, justified experimentally in Section 4.1. When current scores are similar, the mechanism favors the more stable candidate over one with a slightly higher mean but greater variation. For example, if LTE closeness increases steadily with low variance while Wi-Fi closeness fluctuates sharply, C_i^{robust} favors LTE even with slightly higher current Wi-Fi closeness, improving service continuity.

The two enhancements require no LSTM-attention retraining or changes to its inference structure. They apply lightweight statistical and rule-based updates to existing state and score sequences, adding minimal overhead to stacked-LSTM prediction and attention-weight generation. ADH adjusts the handover barrier based on channel variation and speed, while RS-TOPSIS reduces the ranking advantage of volatile candidates. Their impact is limited under stable channels but increases with variation, jointly strengthening environmental awareness and ping-pong suppression at low additional cost.

Algorithm 2 enhances the base closeness score at each decision period. Its C_i input comes from Algorithm 1's TOPSIS steps. RS-TOPSIS first adjusts the ranking score, ADH then updates the dual-hysteresis parameters, and the final decision remains dependent on persistent robust-score advantage.

Algorithm 2 ALERA risk-aware vertical-handover enhancement procedure

Require: Base closeness $\{C_i\}_{i=1}^{3}$ and its latest $K_c = 5$ history, latest five serving-network SINR values, flight speed v, serving network N_{cur}, previous confirmed candidate N_{cand}, and its consecutive count q

Ensure: Enhanced handover decision Decision and updated N_{cur}, N_{cand}, and q

Stage 0: Initialize states and history cache
Read base closeness, SINR history, speed, and previous hysteresis state N_{cand}, q
Stage 1: RS-TOPSIS risk-sensitive ranking
for $i \leftarrow 1$ **to** 3 **do**
    Write C_i to the closeness-history cache and retain the latest K_c periods
    $\sigma_i^C \leftarrow \text{std}(\text{latest } K_c\text{-period history of } C_i)$
    $C_i^{\text{robust}} \leftarrow C_i - 0.5\sigma_i^C$
end for
$N^* \leftarrow \arg\max_i C_i^{\text{robust}}$
Stage 2: ADH adaptive-hysteresis parameter update
$\sigma \leftarrow \text{std}(\text{latest five SINR values of } N_{\text{cur}})$
$\Delta_{\text{th}} \leftarrow 0.03 + 0.05(\sigma/10)$, $T_h \leftarrow \max(2, \lfloor 4 - 2v/30 \rfloor)$
Stage 3: Robust-score dual-hysteresis decision
if $N^* \neq N_{\text{cand}}$ **then**
    $N_{\text{cand}} \leftarrow N^*$, $q \leftarrow 0$
end if
if $C^{\text{robust}}(N^*) - C^{\text{robust}}(N_{\text{cur}}) > \Delta_{\text{th}}$ **then**
    $q \leftarrow q + 1$
else
    $q \leftarrow 0$
end if
if $q \geq T_h$ **then**
    Decision $\leftarrow$ switch to N^*, $N_{\text{cur}} \leftarrow N^*$
else
    Decision $\leftarrow$ keep N_{cur}
end if
return Decision, N_{cur}, N_{cand}, q

3.5. Complexity Analysis and Algorithm Summary

Table 1 summarizes the inputs, outputs, core procedures, and computational complexity of LAAVHA and ALERA in data-flow order. The stacked-LSTM prediction module (Section 3.1) processes the historical state tensor $X_k \in \mathbf{R}^{10\times5}$ through two LSTM layers to generate $S_{\text{pred}} \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times5}$, with

gate-matrix computation as the bottleneck and complexity $O(R \cdot K \cdot d \cdot h^2)$. The dynamic-attention module (Section 3.2) processes $S_{\text{cur}} \in \mathbf{R}^{3\times5}$, incorporates mobility features, and outputs $w \in \mathbf{R}^5$, with self-attention complexity $O(R^2 \cdot d)$. Improved TOPSIS (Section 3.3) fuses and normalizes S_{cur} and S_{pred}, then ranks candidates using weights, producing C_i with overall complexity $O(R \cdot d)$. ADH and RS-TOPSIS use SINR, speed, and C_i history for lightweight statistical updates. End-to-end inference is dominated by LSTM prediction and attention-weight generation, supporting real-time handover decisions in UAV aerial mission scenarios in heterogeneous wireless networks.

Table 1: Summary of the algorithms.

Module	**Input/output**	**Core procedure**	**Complexity**
Stacked-LSTM prediction	In: $3 \times 10 \times 5$ state tensor; out: predicted state	$\text{LSTM}_1(5 \to 128) \to \text{LSTM}_2(128 \to 64) \to \text{fc}(64 \to 5)$	$O(R{\cdot}K{\cdot}d{\cdot}h^2)$
Attention dynamic weights	In: 3×5 state matrix + mobility features; out: 5-D dynamic weights	Self-Attn→mean pooling→ concatenate mobility features→softmax	$O(R^2 \cdot d)$
Improved TOPSIS	In: current + predicted states + dynamic weights; out: candidate closeness C_i	Fused matrix→ weighted normalization→ positive/negative ideal solutions→ closeness	$O(R \cdot d)$
ADH	In: SINR history + flight speed; out: adaptive Δ_{th}, T_h	SINR-variation calculation→linear threshold adjustment→window adaptation	$O(1)$
RS-TOPSIS	In: recent closeness history; out: LCB-adjusted ranking	Historical standard deviation→penalty calculation→ C_i^{robust} ranking	$O(R \cdot K_c)$

4. Simulation Experiments and Results Analysis

4.1. Experimental Platform and Parameter Settings

To evaluate LAAVHA/ALERA in UAV heterogeneous wireless networks, a simulation and inference platform was developed using ns-3.45 [32] and its AI extension ns3-ai [33]. ns-3 implements the 5G/LTE/Wi-Fi topology, UAV mobility, and physical- and transport-layer measurements, while ns3-ai enables bidirectional simulation-inference communication through shared memory. Each decision period transfers a 10-step history of five indicators for three candidate networks (150 dimensions) and the mobility state to shared memory. The inference module loads the trained LAAVHA model, reads the network state, speed, altitude, and current-network identifier, and returns the target-network identifier and candidate scores. Network identifiers are 0=5G, 1=LTE, and 2=Wi-Fi. The model input comprises five indicators for each candidate network (3 networks $\times$10 time steps $\times$5 indicators = 150 dimensions), with each network processed independently by the stacked LSTM. Mobility input comprises speed and altitude. The model outputs a five-dimensional predicted state and dynamic weight, followed by candidate scoring through improved TOPSIS. Fifty random seeds (200–249) simulate aerial missions with varied initial positions and altitudes. Each simulation lasts 10 s with a 0.1 s decision period, yielding 100 decisions. Position and altitude perturbations of 30 m and 10 m, respectively, represent flight deviations.

Before finalizing the parameters in Section 3, three sensitivity experiments were conducted, with results shown in Figure 3. The fusion-coefficient experiment replayed 50 stress sequences involving sustained link degradation and transient fluctuations. Current observations included channel-measurement variation, while predicted states exhibited short-term lag under abrupt changes. For $\alpha = 0.2, 0.4, 0.6, 0.8$, mean false-handover counts were 1.20, 0.90, 0.08, and 1.00, respectively. Lower α increased sensitivity to prediction lag, whereas higher α increased sensitivity to measurement variation. Therefore, $\alpha = 0.6$ provided the best balance, minimizing false handovers and assigning 60% weight to current measurements and 40% to predictions.

Dual-hysteresis and enhancement parameters were evaluated over 50 repetitions of the two competitive intervals used in the subsequent scenario-adaptation experiment: sustained link degradation requiring handover and transient fluctuations that should not trigger handover. Across $\Delta_{\text{th}} \in \{0.03, 0.05, 0.07\}$ and $T_h \in \{2, 3, 4\}$, all combinations achieved 100% necessary-handovers. The

$\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.05, T_h = 3$ setting yielded 0.64 mean false handovers and 1.55 s mean detection delay. The more aggressive $0.03, 2$ setting responded faster but produced 9.10 mean false handovers, whereas the conservative $0.07, 4$ setting eliminated false handovers but increased mean detection delay to 2.00 s. Therefore, $0.05, 3$ was selected to balance stability and response time.

The enhancement parameters $K_c \in \{3, 5, 7\}$ and $\lambda \in \{0.2, 0.5, 0.8\}$ were further evaluated, with all combinations identifying 100% of necessary handovers. At $K_c = 5$, increasing λ from 0.2 to 0.8 reduced mean false handovers from 1.90 to 0.58 but increased mean detection delay from 1.13 s to 1.22 s. At $\lambda = 0.5$, $K_c = 5$ produced 1.08 mean false handovers, compared with 1.48 for $K_c = 3$ and 1.14 for $K_c = 7$, with a mean detection delay of 1.17 s. Considering risk suppression, history stability, and handover timeliness, $K_c = 5, \lambda = 0.5$ were selected.

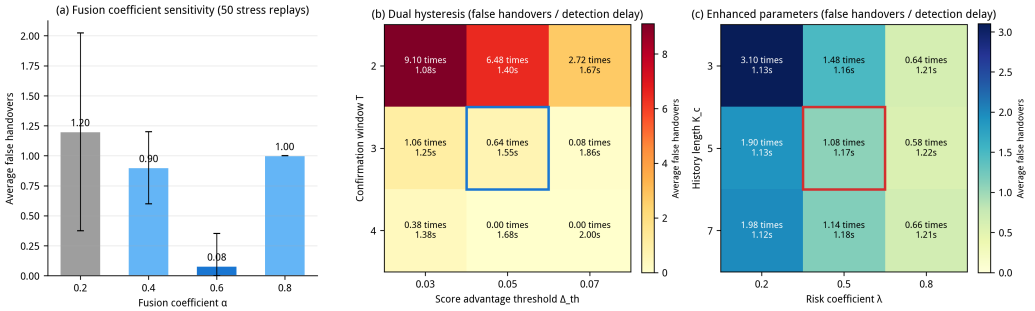


Figure 3: Sensitivity analysis of the fusion coefficient, dual-hysteresis parameters, and enhancement parameters. (For (**b**) and (**c**), upper entries denote mean false-handover counts and lower entries denote mean detection delays.)

Based on these parameter-selection experiments, Table 2 summarizes the platform, network scenario, model architecture, and training/inference parameters. All comparison algorithms use the same simulation configuration, indicator sources, and analysis setting to avoid confounding algorithmic and environmental effects.

Table 2: Experimental parameter settings.

Parameter	**Value**
Simulation platform	ns-3.45, ns3-ai, Python/PyTorch
Candidate networks	5G, LTE, Wi-Fi
Algorithm scope	LAAVHA, 8 comparison algorithms, and 2 ablation variants
Runs	50 random scenarios for each algorithm
Simulation duration	10 s
Decision period	0.1 s
Decisions per run	100
Random seeds	200–249
FlowMonitor mode	feed
Indicator dimensions	SINR, RSRP, delay, throughput, packet loss ratio
Position perturbation	30 m
Altitude perturbation	10 m
Time window T_s	10
LSTM hidden units	128 in the first layer, 64 in the second layer
Attention heads (num_heads)	1 (embed_dim=5; single-head attention)
Fusion coefficient α	0.6
Dual-hysteresis parameters	$\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.05$, confirmation window $T_h = 3$
Enhancement parameters	RS-TOPSIS closeness-history length $K_c = 5$, RS-TOPSIS risk coefficient $\lambda = 0.5$
Training dataset	10,000 samples (historical states and next-period targets)
Dataset split	training/validation = 80%/20% (sample-level random split; see text)
Loss function	MSE (mean squared error) for LSTM prediction only
Optimizer	Adam (learning rate = 0.001)
Batch size	64
Training epochs	50 (maximum)
Early stopping	validation loss does not decrease for 10 consecutive epochs
Trainable parameters	LSTM layers (θ_1, θ_2) and prediction head (W_{pred}, b_{pred})
Fixed parameters	Attention mechanism, W_{mob}, and W_{weight} (Xavier uniform initialization)

In addition to LAAVHA, the experiments evaluate eight comparison algorithms, namely TOPSIS-Q, Fuzzy-VHO, SAW, VIKOR, GRA, COPRAS, SPOTIS, and strongest-signal selection, plus the ablation variants LAAVHA-L and LAAVHA-A. These methods represent seven decision paradigms: fuzzy logic (Fuzzy-VHO), SAW, compromise ranking (VIKOR), distance-based ranking (TOPSIS-Q), relational analysis (GRA), proportional assessment (COPRAS), and reference-point ranking (SPOTIS). TOPSIS-Q follows TOPSIS network selection with entropy-weighted improved TOPSIS [8, 9, 10]; Fuzzy-VHO follows fuzzy handover for 5G UAV networks [4]; VIKOR uses compromise ranking [11]; and GRA, COPRAS, SPOTIS, and SAW represent mainstream multi-attribute mobility decision methods [12]. Strongest-signal selection chooses the candidate with the highest SINR. LAAVHA-L removes LSTM prediction, replacing predicted states with current states while retaining attention weights and dual hysteresis. LAAVHA-A removes attention-based dynamic weighting, retaining LSTM prediction and dual hysteresis while using entropy weighting for TOPSIS.

The training dataset contains 10,000 samples collected from independent ns-3 simulation runs spanning diverse random seeds, UAV trajectories, and channel conditions. Each sample is a pre-built 10-step history window drawn from a distinct simulation episode; adjacent samples in the dataset originate from different runs rather than consecutive time steps of the same trajectory. Samples are therefore statistically independent, and the 80%/20% split in Table 2 is applied at the sample level with no risk of temporal information leakage between training and validation subsets. Min-max normalization is performed per decision period within the simulation at inference time, scaling each of the five indicators across the three candidate networks to $[0, 1]$; the normalization bounds are derived solely from the three-candidate values at that instant and are not fitted or shared across the dataset.

4.2. Decision-Level Simulation Platform

This study evaluates network selection decision-making at the decision level rather than protocol-stack execution. A handover event denotes a change in the network identifier selected by LAAVHA—specifically, which network (5G, LTE, or Wi-Fi) the algorithm chooses at each decision period. It does not represent an actual Wi-Fi disassociation and reassociation, LTE detachment and attachment, or 5G new-radio protocol-stack handover, nor does it include the authentication, link reestablishment, or data-forwarding recovery processes that would occur in a real deployment. The simulation

therefore verifies the stability of network selection decisions (when to switch and which network to select) rather than the end-to-end latency, interruption duration, or protocol overhead of complete handover execution.

The 5G candidate uses a proxy link, with SINR and RSRP calculated by a position-based propagation model following wireless-propagation and link-budget principles [34]. Transport indicators are obtained from FlowMonitor statistics for point-to-point proxy flows. Table 3 summarizes the indicator sources for each candidate network.

Table 3: Candidate-network indicator sources.

Network	**SINR/RSRP**	**Delay**	**Throughput**	**Packet loss ratio**
Wi-Fi	Propagation proxy from MobilityModel position	FlowMonitor	PacketSink bytes received within interval	FlowMonitor
LTE	Propagation proxy from MobilityModel position	FlowMonitor	FlowMonitor	FlowMonitor
5G	Propagation proxy to assumed gNB	Point-to-point proxy-flow FlowMonitor	Point-to-point proxy-flow FlowMonitor	Point-to-point proxy-flow FlowMonitor

Table 3 summarizes the sources of the five network-state indicators in Section 4. SINR and RSRP represent physical-layer link quality and are derived from UAV-access-point/base-station positions using the propagation proxy model. Delay, throughput, and packet loss ratio mainly represent transport-layer service quality. Wi-Fi throughput is calculated from PacketSink bytes received between adjacent periods, whereas LTE and 5G transport indicators are obtained from FlowMonitor. The table defines indicator sources for the decision-level simulation platform rather than a complete real-network protocol-stack measurement procedure. All candidates provide identically dimensioned indicators within each decision period, which LAAVHA and comparison methods uniformly normalize before multi-attribute decision making, ensuring identical candidate states and avoiding collection-related bias.

4.3. Horizontal Comparison of Algorithms

The results evaluate the two challenges at two levels. First, an 11-algorithm comparison, representative decision-process comparison, and ablation study assess whether LSTM prediction, attention-based dynamic weighting, and dual hysteresis improve candidate selection and handover stability. Second, scenario-adaptation experiments under sustained link degradation and abrupt channel changes, such as high-speed coverage-boundary crossings, assess whether ALERA's ADH and RS-TOPSIS preserve necessary handovers while suppressing false and ping-pong handovers. All experiments use the defined performance indicators without introducing additional unmeasured metrics.

To evaluate LAAVHA across decision paradigms, eight representative algorithms were tested under identical conditions. Fuzzy-VHO uses a Mamdani fuzzy-inference system to fuzzify SINR and RSRP and make rule-based decisions. SAW applies fixed weights and sums normalized attributes, representing the basic MADM approach. TOPSIS-Q uses entropy weighting and standard TOPSIS ranking without temporal prediction. GRA ranks candidates by grey relational grades relative to an ideal reference sequence and handles uncertain information. VIKOR balances group utility and individual regret. COPRAS separately evaluates benefit and cost criteria to derive overall utility. SPOTIS ranks candidates by distance to a reference point. Strongest-signal selection chooses the candidate with the highest SINR as a single-factor baseline. Figure 4 compares all 11 algorithms.

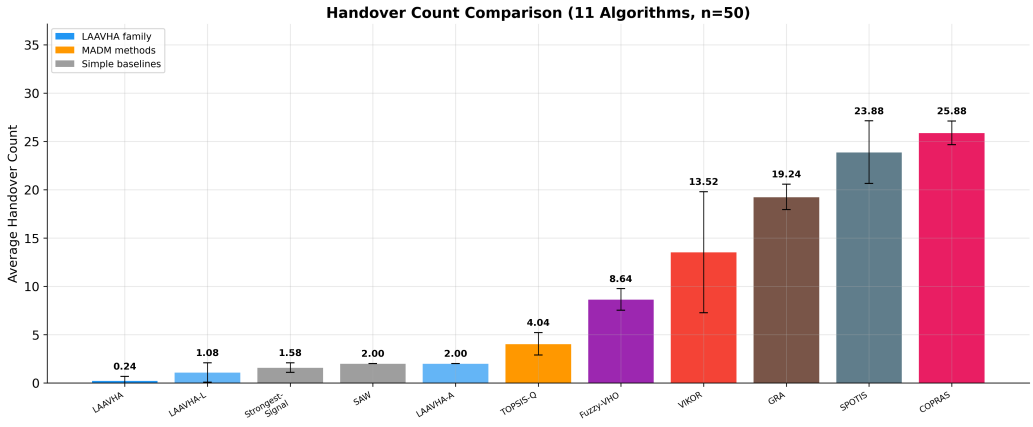


Figure 4: Mean handover-count comparison of 11 algorithms (mean ± std, n=50).

LAAVHA achieves the lowest mean handover count among 11 algorithms, at 0.24 (std=0.43) (Figure 4). Among the eight baselines, strongest-signal selection performs best at 1.58, while SAW, TOPSIS-Q, Fuzzy-VHO, VIKOR, GRA, SPOTIS, and COPRAS yield 2.00, 4.04, 8.64, 13.52, 19.24, 23.88, and 25.88, respectively. These MADM methods use fixed weights and current indicators without temporal prediction or dynamic weighting, allowing alternating candidate-score advantages near coverage boundaries to cause repeated handovers. Strongest-signal selection considers only SINR, excluding delay, throughput, packet loss ratio, and other indicators. Overall, LAAVHA reduces handovers by $84.8\% - 99.1\%$ versus the eight baselines, with 38 of 50 runs producing zero handovers, demonstrating superior handover stability.

To address whether the low handover count reflects excessive conservatism, Table 4 and Figure 5 compare end-to-end communication quality across five representative algorithms under the same 50 scenarios. Three metrics are evaluated: mean throughput (Mbps), mean delay (ms), and mean packet loss ratio (%). The results demonstrate that LAAVHA achieves the best or near-best performance in all three dimensions while maintaining the lowest handover frequency, refuting the hypothesis that reduced handovers necessarily compromise service quality.

Table 4: End-to-end QoS comparison across five representative algorithms (mean ± std, n=50).

Algorithm	**Throughput (Mbps)**	**Delay (ms)**	**Packet Loss (%)**
LAAVHA	2.00 ± 0.12	1.00 ± 0.15	16.33 ± 1.82
TOPSIS-Q	1.98 ± 0.14	1.06 ± 0.18	16.33 ± 1.79
GRA	1.51 ± 0.22	1.39 ± 0.26	17.56 ± 2.41
Strongest-Signal	0.24 ± 0.08	2.29 ± 0.42	15.71 ± 2.03
VIKOR	1.78 ± 0.18	1.20 ± 0.21	16.17 ± 1.95

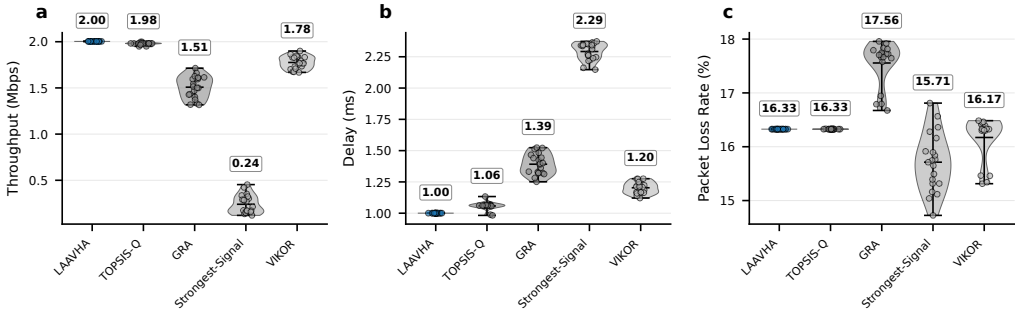


Figure 5: QoS metric distributions across five representative algorithms (n=50). (**a**) Throughput, (**b**) delay, (**c**) packet loss ratio. Violin plots show density; white dots indicate means.

LAAVHA achieves the highest mean throughput (2.00 Mbps) and lowest mean delay (1.00 ms), while maintaining competitive packet loss (16.33%), comparable to TOPSIS-Q. Notably, strongest-signal selection—which also exhibits relatively low handover frequency (1.58)—suffers severely degraded throughput (0.24 Mbps, an 88% reduction) and elevated delay (2.29 ms, 129% higher), demonstrating that low handover count alone does not guarantee service quality. In contrast, LAAVHA's zero-handover scenarios maintain full QoS performance because LSTM prediction and attention-based dynamic weighting enable correct initial network selection, choosing candidates capable of sustaining service throughout the mission. This finding confirms that LAAVHA's handover reduction stems from intelligent decision-making rather than conservative avoidance of necessary reassignments.

The QoS results further substantiate this interpretation. The low handover count reflects intelligent decision-making rather than excessive conservatism. In scenarios with zero handovers, LSTM prediction and attention-based dynamic weighting enable accurate initial network selection, selecting a candidate capable of sustaining service throughout the mission without requiring reassignment. The dual-hysteresis mechanism ($\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.05, T_h = 3$) filters transient boundary fluctuations but does not prevent necessary handovers when sustained degradation occurs. In the 12 runs with one handover, LAAVHA correctly migrates to a better-serving network as conditions evolve, confirming that the algorithm responds to genuine network-state changes. In contrast, baseline algorithms without temporal awareness trigger handovers reactively when current-state scores cross decision boundaries, producing unnecessary reassignments from transient signal variations near coverage edges.

The 38 zero-handover cases do not indicate that LAAVHA avoided required reassignments; rather, predictive candidate evaluation reduced the likelihood that initially suboptimal networks were selected. This distinction is validated by ALERA's behavior under forced degradation (Section 4.6), where the algorithm completes all necessary handovers in Zone 1 while suppressing false handovers in Zone 2, demonstrating that low handover frequency results from stable decision-making, not failure to act when conditions warrant reassignment.

4.4. Comparison of Representative Decision Processes

Figure 6 compares LAAVHA, TOPSIS-Q, and Fuzzy-VHO for the same random seed (seed=200) in a two-row, three-column layout. The selection emphasizes explanatory value rather than aggregate handover count. TOPSIS-Q shares LAAVHA's TOPSIS framework but lacks LSTM prediction, attention-based dynamic weighting, and dual hysteresis, providing a controlled comparison of their effects on closeness stability and handover triggering. Fuzzy-VHO represents a rule-based paradigm driven by fuzzy membership functions and rules, making it more sensitive to local SINR and RSRP fluctuations. Together, they assess dynamic multi-attribute fusion against rule-based handover. Although strongest-signal selection and SAW achieve lower mean counts, strongest-signal uses only SINR and SAW uses fixed weighted sums; neither provides a temporal decision process comparable to LAAVHA and is therefore more suitable for aggregate-statistic comparison.

The upper panels show the integrated TOPSIS closeness scores for 5G, LTE, and Wi-Fi, where values closer to 1 indicate better network service quality; the lower panels show their SINR (dB) under the same simulation, with red dashed lines marking handover times. LAAVHA maintains a stable 5G closeness of $0.99 - 1.00$, while LTE and Wi-Fi remain substantially lower, resulting in no handover under dual hysteresis ($\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.05, T_h = 3$). Although 5G does not always have the largest SINR, attention-based dynamic weights incorporate delay, throughput, packet loss ratio, and other attributes, maintaining its selection. In contrast, TOPSIS-Q triggers several handovers when 5G and Wi-Fi closeness scores converge, while Fuzzy-VHO responds to SINR fluctuations and also triggers multiple handovers. These results demonstrate the stabilizing effects of temporal prediction and dynamic weighting.

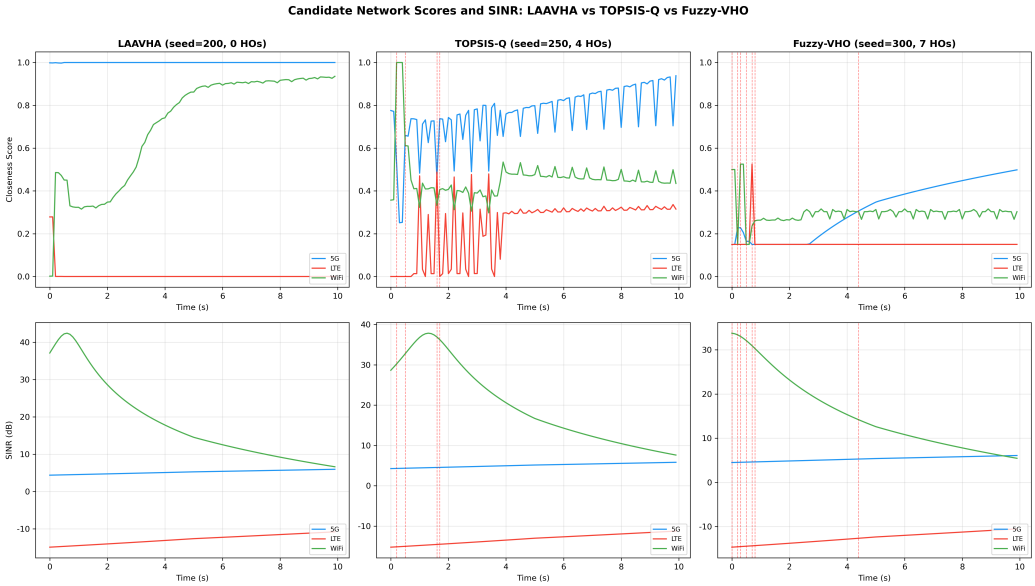


Figure 6: Candidate-network scores and SINR time series for LAAVHA, TOPSIS-Q, Fuzzy-VHO (seed=200; vertical lines indicate handovers).

4.5. Ablation-Study Validation

Ablation experiments quantify the contributions of LSTM prediction and attention-based dynamic weighting to LAAVHA. LAAVHA-L removes LSTM prediction by setting the predicted state equal to the current state while retaining attention weighting, improved TOPSIS, and dual hysteresis, testing temporal prediction. LAAVHA-A removes attention-based dynamic weighting, retains LSTM prediction, improved TOPSIS, and dual hysteresis, and replaces attention weights with entropy weights, testing dynamic-weight learning. Both variants and full LAAVHA use the same 50 random seeds (200−249) and simulation parameters. Figure 7 presents handover counts with scatter-overlaid bars, where each point represents one run, bar height is the mean, and error bars ±1 are the standard deviation. LAAVHA achieves 0.24 (std=0.43), with 38 zero-handover and 12 one-handover runs, demonstrating stable cooperation between prediction and dynamic weighting. LAAVHA-L increases to 1.08 (std = 1.01), showing that removing temporal prediction produces more reactive and variable decisions. LAAVHA-A reaches 2.00 (std = 0.00), with two handovers in all 50 runs, indicating that entropy weighting cannot adapt criteria to the flight phase and leads to ping-pong handovers near the Wi-Fi coverage edge. Notably, this eightfold improvement (0.24 vs.

2.00) is achieved despite the attention module having never been trained via gradient descent (Section 3.2); its parameters were initialized using Xavier uniform and remained fixed throughout training. The result validates that the attention mechanism's structural design—query-key attribute interaction combined with mobility-aware projection—provides sufficient adaptivity through its architectural inductive bias alone, without requiring end-to-end optimization.

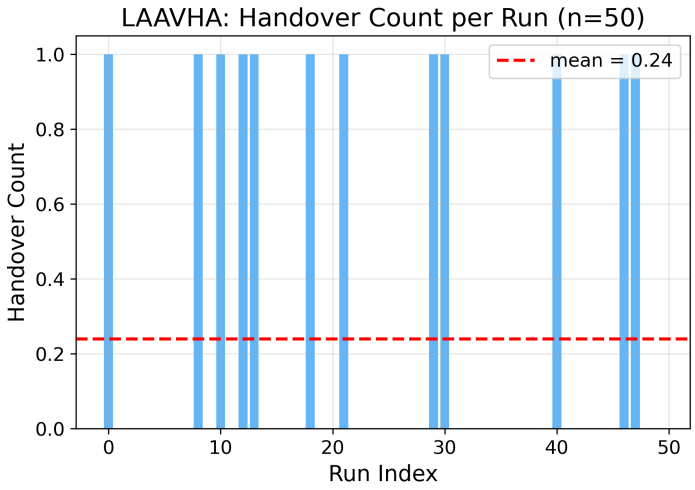


Figure 7: Handover-count comparison in the LAAVHA ablation study (mean ± std, n=50).

The ablation results demonstrate strong synergy between LSTM prediction and attention-based dynamic weighting; neither module alone maintains low handover frequency. Removing attention has the largest effect, increasing the mean from 0.24 to 2.00, an eightfold rise across all 50 runs, showing that flight- and network-state-based weights adapt to phase-specific requirements better than static statistical weights. Removing the LSTM increases the mean to 1.08 with higher variance (std = 1.01), confirming the importance of temporal prediction for stability. Together, these results validate the LAAVHA architecture.

4.6. Scenario Adaptation and Enhancement Validation

To evaluate ALERA under rapid coverage-boundary crossings and abrupt channel changes, a competitive scenario is constructed with network A, analogous to 5G, and network B, analogous to Wi-Fi, having closeness scores near

0.50; A is initially serving. The scenario represents two data transmission conditions: timely migration under sustained degradation and handover suppression under transient disturbances from short obstructions or multipath effects. Figure 8 shares the time axis across four panels, with $t = 5 - 8$ s and $t = 12 - 15$ s denoting the same intervals in panels a–d. Light-blue Zone 1 represents sustained degradation, where A declines and B improves, requiring a correct A-to-B handover. Light-red Zone 2 represents transient fluctuations, where sinusoidal variation and Gaussian noise are injected into B; short peaks provide no sustained mean advantage and should not trigger handover.

Panel (a) of Figure 8 shows raw closeness curves. The vertical axis represents the candidate's integrated score before risk penalization, with higher values indicating greater proximity to the ideal candidate. Network B maintains a persistent advantage in Zone 1, whereas its Zone 2 increase is a transient high-frequency oscillation.

Panel (b) shows handovers under the fixed low threshold ($\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.03$); the vertical axis is raw closeness, and red dashed lines mark handover times and directions. Correct A→B and B→A handovers occur at $t = 6.6$ s and $t = 11.9$ s, respectively, corresponding to sustained degradation and subsequent recovery. In Zone 2, transient peaks trigger A→B at $t = 14.8$ s and B→A at $t = 15.1$ s, producing a false handover and subsequent ping-pong handover.

Panel (c) presents ALERA's risk-adjusted scores, with the vertical axis $C_i^{\text{robust}} = C_i - \lambda\sigma_i^C$, with green dashed lines indicating handovers. ALERA retains both necessary handovers while suppressing Zone 2 fluctuations and avoiding handover.

Panel (d) shows the adaptive threshold Δ_{th}, representing the required closeness advantage. In Zone 2, it increases from 0.03 to approximately 0.08 and gradually decreases after fluctuations subside, demonstrating that ADH raises the handover barrier only under unstable conditions.

The enhancement provides two key benefits. Under sustained degradation, it completes the necessary handover from degraded network A to better network B, avoiding excessive conservatism. Under transient variation, it suppresses false handovers caused by short peaks and prevents A→B→A ping-pong. RS-TOPSIS reduces the ranking advantage of volatile candidates, determining which network to switch to, while ADH raises the trigger threshold during fluctuations, determining when to switch. Together, they preserve necessary handovers, reduce false handovers, and limit associated link-reestablishment overhead.

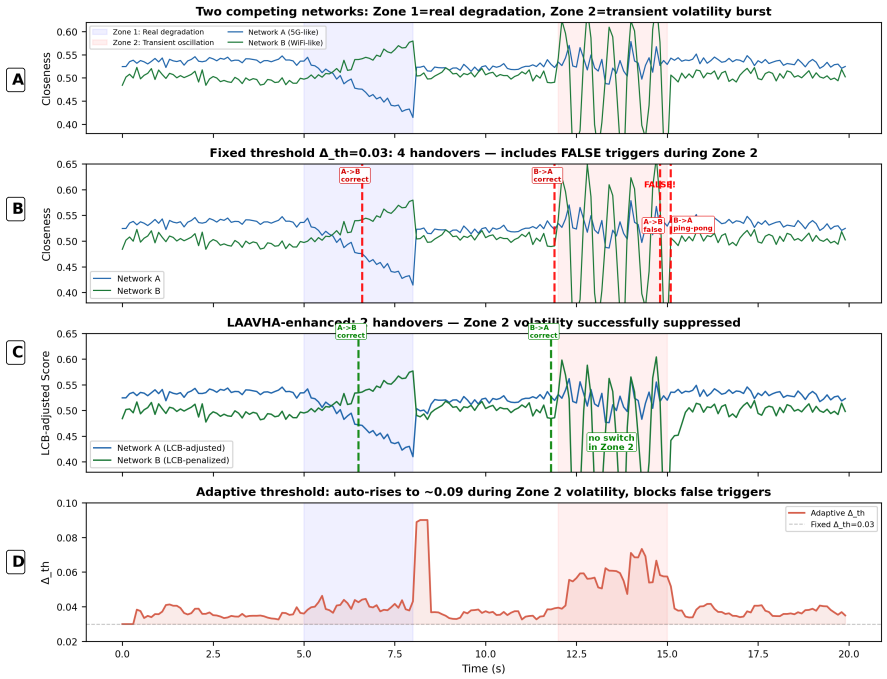


Figure 8: Adaptive-hysteresis validation of fixed low threshold ($\Delta_{\text{th}} = 0.03$) and ALERA under sustained degradation and transient fluctuation.

5. Conclusion

For VHO challenges arising from wide-area flight, heterogeneous coverage, and rapid link-state changes in UAV heterogeneous wireless networks, this paper proposes LAAVHA and its enhanced version, ALERA. LAAVHA integrates stacked-LSTM short-term state prediction, attention-based dynamic attribute weighting, improved TOPSIS using current and predicted states, and dual-hysteresis decision-making. This joint use of temporal evolution, flight state, and multi-attribute service requirements reduces handovers caused by transient boundary fluctuations. Without altering the LSTM-attention architecture or training parameters, ALERA adds ADH to adapt the handover threshold and confirmation window to serving-network SINR variation and flight speed, and RS-TOPSIS to penalize historical closeness variation. Therefore, it improves adaptation through both "when to switch" and "which network to switch to." Across 50 random seeds, LAAVHA achieves the lowest mean decision-level handover count among 11 algorithms (0.24), reducing handovers by 84.8% – 99.1% versus eight baselines, with

38 of 50 runs requiring none. End-to-end QoS evaluation confirms that this handover reduction does not compromise service quality: LAAVHA achieves the highest mean throughput (2.00 Mbps) and lowest mean delay (1.00 ms), demonstrating that low handover frequency results from intelligent network selection rather than excessive conservatism. Removing LSTM prediction or dynamic attention weighting increases the mean to 1.08 and 2.00, respectively. At the decision level, ALERA completes all necessary network selection changes under sustained degradation and produces zero false changes under transient variation, demonstrating stable decision-making for UAV aerial missions in heterogeneous wireless networks. The simulation evaluates the stability and correctness of network selection decisions (when to switch and which network to select); future work will extend the evaluation to include complete protocol-stack handover processes, such as authentication delays, link reestablishment overhead, and seamless data forwarding.

Author Contributions

Conceptualization, H.S. and B.D.; methodology, H.S.; software, H.S.; validation, H.S., T.L. and W.S.; formal analysis, H.S.; investigation, T.L. and J.L. (Jie Lin); resources, B.D.; data curation, W.S.; writing—original draft preparation, H.S.; writing—review and editing, B.D. and J.L. (Junsong Luo); visualization, H.S.; supervision, B.D.; project administration, B.D.; funding acquisition, B.D. All authors have read and agreed to the published version of the manuscript.

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Data Availability Statement

The simulation code and the data generated in this study are available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request.

Conflicts of Interest

The authors declare no conflicts of interest.

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